

A SECOND RECKONING, KEYED AND READY TO RUN

BLOOD & GRIT

A ROLEPLAYING GAME OF THE HAUNTED
FRONTIER

A FACE NOT HIS OWN

Module II · A one-night adventure for four souls at 3rd level · Version 1.2

Eight souls are at Saltlick Station tonight. One of them is wearing somebody.





"A man is his face to everybody but his mother, and his mother was forty years dead, so there was nobody at that station qualified to say."

— MARSHAL ADELIA CRUZ, ON THE SALTICK INQUEST



"Count them. Count them out loud, and count them again in an hour, and if the number is the same both times you have still learned nothing."

— ADVICE WRITTEN INSIDE A STATION-KEEPER'S LEDGER, SALTICK



Blood & Grit · Module II · A Face Not His Own · Version 1.2 · For the Keeper Alone

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What This Is



A locked room is only frightening while the door is the problem.

— A NOTE PINNED INSIDE THE COVER OF THE FIRST PRINTING



One night at the table, for four souls at 3rd level, at a relay station on the north road out of Perdition Basin. Three to four hours. Every creature in it is printed here in full, so the Bestiary can stay on the shelf.

It is a different animal from *The Salt at Coffin Wells* and it is meant to be. Module I was a night of things coming at the posse out of the dark. This is a night of things already inside, sitting at the same table, passing the salt. Nothing charges the door. The horror is that the posse has to decide, out loud, in front of everybody, which of eight frightened people is not a person, and then be wrong at least once.

What You Need

The Player's Book for the souls, and this. The Keeper's Book is useful and not required. If you are running GritKeeper at the table, put all eight of the station's people on the Posse tab as NPCs before you start; the act of deleting a row when one of them stops being a person does more work at a table than any description will.

What It Teaches, and in What Order

Three things, one per act, and never two at once.

- **Act One teaches that the horror can talk.** No fight at all. One Dread Check on a man answering to the wrong name, and a long hour of eight people being ordinary at each other.
- **Act Two teaches the cost of being certain.** Two of the station's people are already gone and the posse has to fight them in a room eleven feet across. Somebody at your table will kill a person who was still a person. The module is built to let that happen and not to punish it.
- **Act Three teaches that the answer was written down.** Unlike module I, this fight *can* be won on the field, though the engine says it usually is not, and says why. See [What the Night Costs](#).

BEFORE YOU RUN IT

Read the Eight before you read the acts. This module is a cast, a building, and a rule about what the thing can and cannot do; the three acts are just the order those meet the posse in. A Keeper who knows the eight can improvise the whole night. A Keeper who has memorised the acts and not the people will be reading when they should be answering.

The Truth of It

For the Keeper alone. Nobody at Saltlick knows any of this, including the two who are no longer people.

Eleven days ago the down coach put off a passenger at Saltlick who had boarded at the north line as Mr. Amos Dell, commercial traveller in patent remedies. Mr. Dell had been dead since the Tuesday previous. What got off the coach had been wearing him for four days and had learned, in that time, that a man travelling alone is the easiest thing in the world to be.

It came south because it had used up the north. It is not hunting the posse and it is not hunting the station. It is doing what it has done in five towns already: settling in, taking one soul at a time, and leaving before the count gets noticed. Saltlick is a stop, not a destination. That is the coldest thing about it and the module should let the players work it out for themselves.

Who It Has Already Taken

Two, before the module opens. **Amos Dell** is the skin it arrived in. **Cal Mears, the hostler**, it took on the fourth night. It keeps both, and it wears whichever the room calls for, but a thing wearing two faces cannot keep both in the same room, and that is the whole solution to this module.

What is left of the men themselves is in the ice house, and the ice house is the only door at Saltlick anybody has bothered to lock.

The Tell

It has the face, the voice, the hands and the memories. What it does not have is the habit. **Neither Dell nor Mears is ever in the same room as the other.** They are always just gone to the barn, just stepped out, just turned in. Six of the station's people will tell the posse both men are here tonight and not one of them has seen them together.

THE ONE THING TO RUN WELL

Do not withhold this and do not hand it over. Say, unprompted, that Dell has just gone out to see to the team, whenever Mears is on stage. Say Mears is in the barn whenever Dell is. Say it four or five times across Act One in exactly that flat, ordinary way, and put nothing on it. The table will hear it eventually, and the moment somebody at the table says the words out loud is the best moment this module has.

The Clock

The Count at Saltlick*4 segments*

Fill a segment each time the posse spends a scene on the wrong person, and each time an hour passes with nobody named. At four, it stops needing the face: Act Three opens whether the posse is ready or not, and it opens in whatever room they are standing in.

The Hook, and Getting Them There

The norther came down off the mesa about three and by four you could not see the trail. Saltlick Station has a light in it and a barn with a roof, and the man on the step is waving you in with both arms like he has been waiting all day for somebody to be glad to see.

They do not need a reason to be here. They need a reason not to leave, and the weather is it. The norther runs until first light and the module ends at first light, which is not a coincidence.

Three Ways In

- **The weather.** Simplest and best. They are on the north road, it turns, and Saltlick is the only roof in eleven miles.
- **The coach.** They are riding it, or escorting it, or waiting on it. It is due at dawn and it will arrive on time, which matters; see the ride out.
- **Following module I.** The scrap of worked silver off Tom Pell's body has a mate. Marshal Cruz has heard of a traveller in patent remedies buying old church silver up and down the north line and paying too much for it. That is a true rumour and a false lead: the thing buys silver to know where it is.

Ollie Gant, station keeper

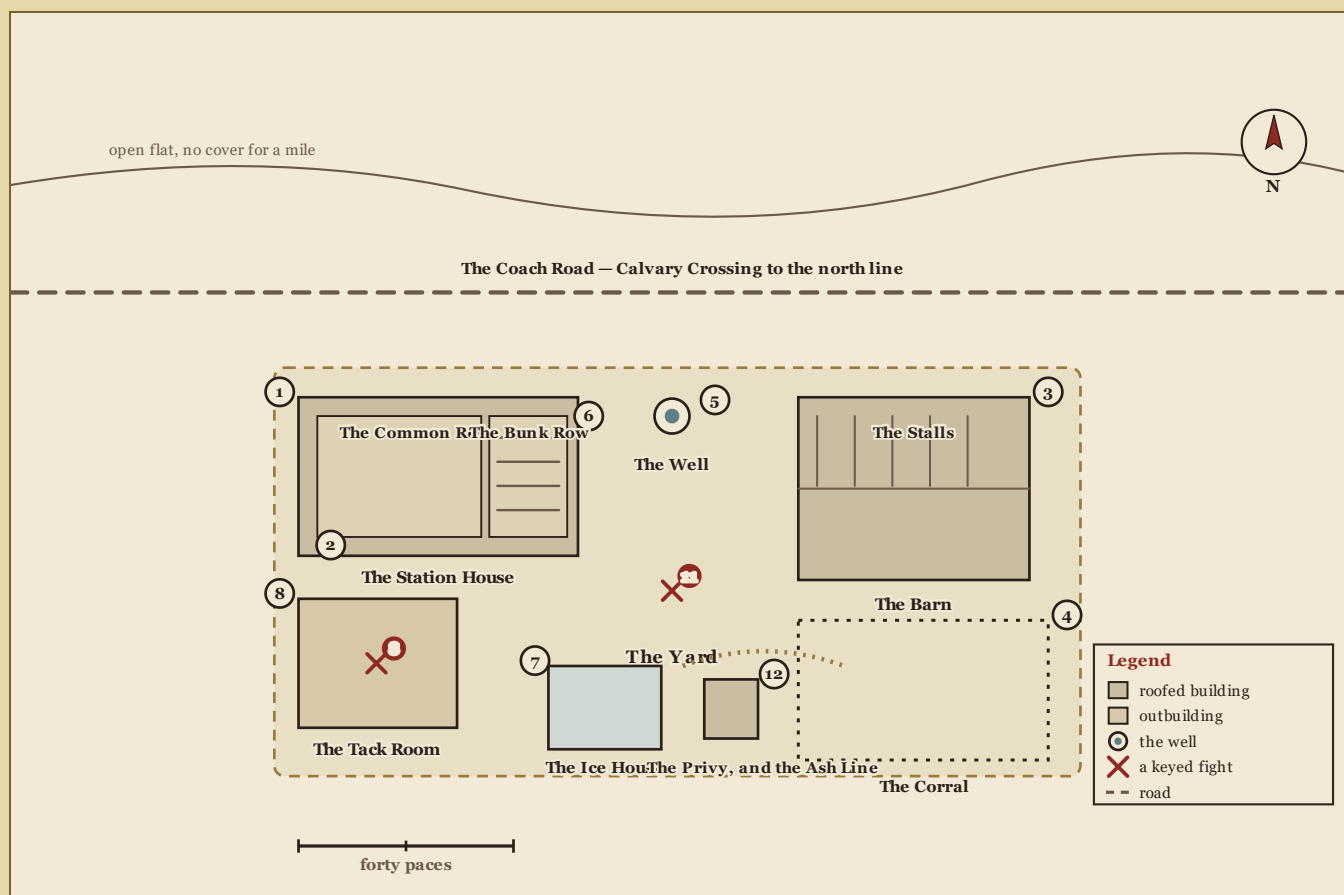
WANTS the coach to come on time and nothing else to happen ever again

LEVER he is proud of his station and will not have it called unclean

"Eleven days without a word of trouble. You will want to not be the trouble."

The Ground

Every numbered place below is a keyed scene, and the number on the map is the number in the margin of the act it belongs to.



Saltlick Station — the whole of the night, four buildings and a yard, with the twelve keyed scenes pinned where they happen

What the Shape of It Does

Saltlick is four buildings around a yard forty paces across, on a flat with no cover for a mile in any direction. That geometry is doing three jobs and it is worth knowing which.

- **Nobody can leave.** The doors are not locked. It is dark, and blowing, and there is nowhere to go. The players will test this. Let them, once, briefly, and let the country turn them around.
- **Everybody keeps crossing the yard.** Which is how the posse can be told six times that both men are here and never see them together.
- **The last act has an open field.** Act Three is fought in the yard on purpose: forty paces of nothing, at first light, with a line of ash across it.

KEEPER

Hand the map to the table. There is nothing on it the posse cannot see from the step, and a table that can point at the ice house will use the ice house. The download beside it prints on one sheet.

Act One – The Wrong Note Among Friends

Aim for an hour. No fight. One Dread Check, and eight people being ordinary.

1. The Station House

Low, long, warm, and smelling of coffee and wet wool. Gant takes their coats and tells them the rules of his house, which are: pay for what you eat, do not go in the ice house, and do not wake the passengers before five.

The ice house rule is the only one he means. He means it because there is a side of beef in there he has been over-charging for, and he is embarrassed. He does not know what else is in there.

2. The Common Room, and Eight Names

Introduce all eight here, quickly, in one pass, the way a room actually introduces itself. Full entries under The Eight. Do not slow down for them and do not let a player interview them one at a time yet; the room should feel crowded and cheerful and slightly too loud.

Somebody is losing at cards, badly and happily. The Chinese cook is arguing about the price of coal with a woman who is not paying for the coal. And a big man by the fire says, without looking up: "Cal's got the team. Dell's gone out to help him. They'll want feeding when they're in."

KEEPER

That is the first plant and it is deliberately worthless. Nobody should notice it. Say four more like it across this act, always about the same two men, always in somebody else's mouth, always while one of them is in the room.

3. The Barn

Warm, dark, full of the noise of animals not settling. The stalls are along the north wall and the horses in the two nearest the door will not stand: they have been moved twice tonight and they will be moved again.

A Mountain Man or anyone with a hand for stock reads this in a moment: the horses are not spooked at the weather. They are spooked at a thing that keeps walking past them.

4. The Corral, and the Horses That Will Not

Six head, outside, in a norther, because they would not come in. Gant is angry about it and has given up. Anyone who works them can get them as far as the barn door and no further.

SIGN OF IT. In the heart of a community, wearing someone's face — a homestead, a small town, a trail party, a fort. It hunts the isolated to take their shape, then walks back in among people as one of them.

The Dread Check of Act One

Dread Check, DC 15, Will save. Tier II loss. It fires the first time somebody calls the hostler by name and he answers to the wrong one. He says “Amos” is fine, or he answers to Cal a half-second late, and then laughs it off so smoothly that the moment closes before anyone can put a hand on it.

KEEPER

One check, and it is on the wrongness rather than on anything seen. Nobody at this table has seen a monster yet and the module is in no hurry for them to. Sleep is a Toll rather than a scene: a night in the cold with the doors barred costs each soul 2 Blood and nothing else.

Act Two – The First Taking

Aim for ninety minutes. One Dread Check, one fight in a very small room.

5. The Well

The bucket comes up with a coat button in it, and the coat is hanging by the door, and its owner has been asleep in the bunk row for four hours and can prove it.

It is a real clue and it points at nothing. The thing dropped it crossing the yard four nights ago. Let the posse spend a scene on it if they want, and fill a segment of the clock when they do, because that is exactly what the clock is for.

6. The Bunk Row

Six bunks, a curtain, and no privacy at all. This is where the posse can get people alone, and it is where the module wants them: one soul, one lamp, one frightened person, and a question.

Everybody here will answer honestly. Six of them will say both Dell and Mears are at the station tonight. Asked directly — *when did you last see the two of them together?* — every one of them will stop, and think, and not be able to say.

THE HINGE

This is the scene the module exists for. Do not rush it and do not help. If nobody asks the question, they do not get the answer, and Act Three simply costs more. If somebody does ask it, give them the pause and the honest, frightened, useless answer, and then let the table do the rest.

7. The Ice House

Locked, and Gant has the key on him and will not give it up for asking. Behind the beef, under sacking, are Amos Dell and Cal Mears: both of them, both intact, both wearing the clothes they were taken in, and neither of them marked anywhere a coat would not cover.

Dread Check, DC 17, Will save. Tier II loss. Not for the bodies. For the arithmetic the posse does standing over them, which is that both of these men were at supper.

8. The Tack Room

Eleven feet by nine, one door, hooks and harness on every wall, a lamp on a nail. Whatever the posse has worked out, this is where it stops being talk: the two it has already been inside come off the wall at them, in the dark, in a room too small to back out of.

SIGN OF IT. Anywhere a door was left open — a house where a ward broke, a person who dabbled and lost, a survivor of another haunting. The host is usually someone with a connection to the party or the community, to make the stakes personal.

Full entry under What Wears a Face Here. Two of them. It has finished with both bodies and left behind whatever it put in them, and both still wear the faces the posse has been sharing a room with all night.

KEEPER

The engine says the posse wins this one: ten clears in twelve, in about two rounds. That is by design. Act Two is the fight this module lets them have, so that Act Three can be the one it does not. Let it be brutal and fast and let them win it.

If a player refuses to fire on a face they know, that is not a problem to solve. Let them hold, let it cost them, and let another soul do it. Then remember which of them hesitated, because Act Three will ask again.

Act Three – The Tell Made Plain

Aim for an hour. One Dread Check, one open field, and a sunrise.

9. It Stops Pretending

Dread Check, DC 18, Will save. Tier III loss. It happens when the last face comes off, and the module is specific about how: it does not tear, and it does not melt. The man standing in front of them simply stops doing the thousand small things a man does, all at once, and goes still in a way nothing alive goes still, and then it is not wearing anybody at all.

It has been holding its shoulders like a man who is cold. It stops. It does not put them down — it stops holding them, and they are not where a man's shoulders are. "You counted," it says, in Cal Mears's voice, and it sounds pleased. "Five towns and nobody counted."

10. The Count

Whoever is still alive gets one scene (sixty seconds at the table) to do something with what they know before it comes across the yard. This is where the ash line gets laid, or the mirror gets fetched off the wall of the bunk row, or somebody works a Sign, or the Preacher prays over a handful of shot.

SAY THE THREE OUT LOUD IF YOU HAVE TO

Everything a posse can do here is printed in the creature's own entry and the entry is on the next page. It cannot abide its true reflection. It cannot cross a line of ash and bone. A prayed-over or silver bullet wounds it past the borrowed skin. There is a mirror in the bunk row, there is a stove full of ash and a yard full of bone-meal for the stock, and there is a Preacher. The module has been putting all three in front of them since Act One.

11. The Yard at First Light

Forty paces of open ground, going gray at the east end. It comes across it without hurrying, because it has done this in five towns and it has not yet met the one that counted in time.

SIGN OF IT. In the heart of a community, wearing someone's face — a homestead, a small town, a trail party, a fort. It hunts the isolated to take their shape, then walks back in among people as one of them.

Full entry under What Wears a Face Here. Unlike module I, the safe-table rule does *not* refuse this fight: a 3rd-level posse is Tier 2 and a Skin-Walker is Tier III, one rung over, which the book calls a hard fight rather than an impossible one. The app will seat it on the field without arguing.

KEEPER

And the engine still says they will not win it by shooting. Twelve runs, zero clears, every one of them broken off — see What the Night Costs. The difference from module I is the reason. Module I's boss had no answer on the field at all. This one is a fight the posse loses on the numbers by a little, and one prepared thing flips it. The mirror does not kill it. The mirror makes it hesitate, and hesitation is the whole margin.

12. The Ash Line

Behind the privy is a barrel of stove ash and, in the barn, forty pounds of bone-meal bought for the stock. A line of the two mixed, laid across the yard, is the second half of the creature's own answer — and it does not have to be a big line. It has to be between the thing and the door it wants.

Laying it is one action and anyone can take it. Crossing it is the one thing the Skin-Walker cannot do, and the module is emphatic that a Keeper should honour that absolutely: no save, no roll, no exception. A rule the country obeys without a die is worth more to a table than any ten it negotiates.

The Coach at Dawn

The escape valve, and it is always available. The down coach makes Saltlick at first light, every day, and it makes it tonight. Six armed strangers and a shotgun messenger arriving in the middle of an open-field fight will end it, one way or the other. It costs the posse the ending. It does not cost them the night.

The Eight

A want, a lever, and a line, per the Keeper's Book Ch. VIII. Two of these people are already gone; the entries do not say which, because the Keeper already knows and the page is easier to read at the table if it treats them all alike.

Ollie Gant, station keeper

WANTS his station to be a clean-run house that the company never has to think about

LEVER the ice house key is on his belt and his pride is the lock on it

"There has been no trouble here in eleven days and I intend to keep the run going."

Amos Dell, traveller in patent remedies

WANTS to be found agreeable and then forgotten

LEVER he is generous with his stock and nobody can name a thing he has sold

"Take two of these for the cold. No, no charge. I have had a good month."

Cal Mears, hostler

WANTS the horses settled and the night over

LEVER he is the only man here the animals will not go near, and he has noticed

"They have been like this since the weather turned. Stock know weather."

Mrs. Ada Follett, going east to bury a brother

WANTS to get where she is going and not be spoken to kindly

LEVER she is the sharpest observer in the building and nobody has asked her anything

"I have been watching that room for four hours, and I would not care to say what I have seen."

Wu Cheng-hsi, who cooks and keeps the accounts

WANTS the coal money settled and the coach on time

LEVER he keeps the station's ledger, and the ledger records who was fed and when

"Eight at supper. Eight plates. I do not make a mistake with plates."

Deputy Sam Orr, moving a prisoner east

WANTS his prisoner delivered and no complications on the paper

LEVER he will not unchain the man for anything, which is either the safest thing in the building or the cruellest

"Whatever this is, it is not my business and he is not going anywhere."

Bill Teague, in irons, being moved for a hanging

WANTS not to be in this building when whatever it is finishes

LEVER he has been awake and chained in the common room for four nights and has seen more of the station than anyone alive

"I ain't seen those two men in a room together. Four nights. Ask me again slow."

Tobe, the boy who does the boots, fourteen

WANTS to be treated as one of the men

LEVER he goes everywhere, he is invisible, and he has been in the ice house twice

"There's a smell in there ain't beef. I said. Nobody wanted it said."

KEEPER

Teague and Tobe are the two who hand the posse the answer, and both are people the West trains a table to discount: a man in irons and a boy. That is the point and it is not subtle. Play it straight and let the table find it.

What Wears a Face Here

Printed in full so the Bestiary can stay on the shelf. These entries are generated from the same file the app reads, so they cannot drift from the book they came out of.

The Possessed

The Possessed

Tier II · Tier II · a soul with a rider

DEFENSE 12 (host)

BLOOD 22

SPEED normal

SAVES Fort +5, Ref +6, Will +9

ATTACKS the host's hands, made strong +6 (1d8+3); speaks in a borrowed, wrong voice

SPECIAL Two in one skin. An innocent person ridden by something else; every wound you deal, you deal to the host you may be trying to save.

DREAD DC 16, 1d6

PUTTING IT DOWN Drive the rider out — a true exorcism, a holy ground, the thing's name — without killing the host. Kill the body and the rider only finds another.

Two, in the tack room, and both of them are faces the posse has eaten supper with. Play them as people who are still trying to say something.

The Skin-Walker

The Skin-Walker

Tier III · Tier III · the thing that wears men

DEFENSE 17

BLOOD 38

SPEED fast in any shape

SAVES Fort +9, Ref +11, Will +6

ATTACKS claws +9 (2d6+4, two a round), or whatever the borrowed shape carries

SPECIAL Another's skin. Wears the face and manner of any it has killed; one thing is always wrong — a shadow, a reflection, an animal's terror, the eyes by firelight.

DREAD DC 16, 1d6 (when it sheds a face)

The Skin-Walker

Tier III · Tier III · the thing that wears men

(cont.)

PUTTING IT DOWN It cannot abide its true reflection nor cross a line of ash and bone; a prayed-over or silver bullet wounds past the borrowed skin.

One, in the yard, at first light. Read its Putting It Down line to yourself twice before Act Three: all three of its answers are keyed into the station, and none of them is an attack roll.

WHY THE APP IS QUIET THIS TIME

On the safe-table rule, and why it is quiet this time. A Skin-Walker is Tier III and a 3rd-level posse is Tier 2 (one rung over, not two), so GritKeeper will seat this fight on the field without a word. Module I's Nightwalker was two rungs over and the app argues about it. The rule has not changed; the posse has. That is worth pointing at, because a table that only ever meets the rule when it refuses something never learns what it is actually measuring.

What the Night Costs

Every number on this page came out of the game's own engine. Twelve posses (a Gunhand, a Preacher, a Mountain Man and a Sawbones, built by the generator, at 3rd level) were run through all three acts on the same rules library the app runs on, with the Bestiary's numbers for every foe and the book's dice for every roll. The runs are seeded and reproduce.

They were run twice over: once *cold*, with no recovery between acts and no Grit spent and no Sign or Miracle worked, and once *tended*, with the posse back to half Blood between acts.

FIGHT	TIER	CLEARED	BROKE OFF	ROUNDS	POSSE HITS	ITS HITS
The tack room (Act Two)	II	8 of 12	4 of 12	2.1	42%	59%
The yard at first light (Act Three)	III	0 of 8	8 of 8	1.5	20%	72%

Nobody died. Across twelve cold runs the posse was never put down to the last soul, not once, and they never finished the night on their feet either. Twelve out of twelve broke off and rode out. Souls down at the end averaged 2.2 of 4, and Nerve finished at 49.6 of a possible 71, with one run in twelve seeing a soul break outright.

That is a very particular shape and it is the shape this module was built for. The Act Two fight is a fight the posse wins. The Act Three fight is a fight the posse survives. Giving them back half their Blood between acts changed neither count, which is how you know the difference between the two rows is not attrition.

KEEPER

Twenty per cent, against seventy-two. That is the Act Three row, whole. Four souls trading Strikes at rising MAP against Defense 17 land one blow in five, and it hits back nearly three times in four. A round and a half of that is the entire fight. Bring nothing to the yard, and the yard is a countdown.

Now put one prepared thing in their hands. A mirror off the bunk-room wall costs it its first round. A line of ash and bone takes the yard away from it. Silver or prayed-over shot moves that twenty per cent to something that matters. None of those is a house rule: all three are printed in the creature's own entry, three pages back.

Against Module I

The same harness ran *The Salt at Coffin Wells* at 1st level and this at 3rd, and the two Tier III fights failed differently. The Nightwalker was never beaten and never could be: it is two Tiers over the posse and the safe-table rule says so out loud. The Skin-Walker is one Tier over, the app seats it without complaint, and the engine never once cleared it; but every posse that reached the yard was a posse that only shot at it.

Module I's lesson is that some things are not fights. This one's is narrower and harder: some things are fights you lose unless you did something first.

Scaling the Night

- **A bigger or bolder posse.** Three Possessed in the tack room instead of two. Have it take Tobe in Act Two, so the posse is fighting a boy in Act Three. Do not add Blood to the Skin-Walker; take the mirror away instead.
- **A smaller or greener posse.** One Possessed. Let Mrs. Follett say what she has seen without being asked. Have the ash barrel already standing open in the yard, where somebody will trip over it.
- **If the dice turn cruel.** The coach is always one scene away. Use it.

The Ride Out, and What Comes After

However it ends, give it weight before anybody rolls anything else.

If they put it down

Six people live who would not have. Two of them will not thank the posse, because two of them watched a stranger shoot somebody they knew by name. Let Saltlick be grateful and unfriendly at the same time, which is how a place is when it has been saved from something it still does not believe in.

If it walks away

Or if the fourth segment filled and it did not need the face any more. Do not run this as a failure. It leaves wearing somebody, and the somebody is a person the posse spent a night with. Six towns now. It has learned that a posse can count, which makes it careful, which makes it slower and worse and further away.

The Coach

It arrives at first light either way and it goes east on time, and whoever gets on it is a decision the table makes in front of each other. If nobody thought to look at who boarded, say so plainly, once, three sessions from now.



*A thing that can sit at your table can be beaten at your table. That is the only
comfort in it and it is a real one.*

— FROM A KEEPER'S LEDGER, QUOTED IN THE KEEPER'S BOOK



What comes next

Module III, *What the Water Answers*, goes south and down, to Mission San Clavo and the shaft beneath it, for a posse at 5th level. Both earlier modules end within sight of that mission and neither one goes inside. That one does.

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Every person, place and thing in this night, and the page it waits on.



Scene numbers run 1–12 across the three acts and are keyed in the margin of each, and on the map in The Ground.

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